

"The anti-Naxal strategy is a flop. Someone picked up the strategy from some book and forced it down the throats of the paramilitary forces."

KPS GILL Former Punjab Police chief



REUTERS



MAOIST LEADER KISHEN WITH A LOOTED INSAS RIFLE ON HIS BACK

LOOT AND SCOOT

Every attack yields headlines and a cache of arms and ammunition for the Maoists

Somewhere along the red corridor, the Maoists are equipping an entire company (nearly 100 men) with AK 47s, INSAS rifles and light machine guns (LMGs). These are the spoils from the deadly ambush of the CRPF company in Dantewada. Power flows from the barrel of a gun, Mao once famously said. For his self-proclaimed followers, the Maoists, who have declared war against the Indian state, the gun is supreme. "Safeguard your weapons like you would your own life," a Maoist training manual exhorts. Insurgents in Jammu and Kashmir smuggle their AK-47s from across the border, the Naga and Mizo insurgents buy theirs from the thriving arms bazaar in Myanmar and China but a majority of the Maoist arsenal comprises weapons looted by

ambushing security forces over the past five years.

If the tragedy of losing 76 police personnel in a single ambush in Dantewada is not enough, there is the frightening prospect of their weapons being used against forces elsewhere in the Red Corridor—Indian-built weapons being turned against Indian security forces. There is a tragic, fratricidal ring to this. "We feel bad and helpless when we see this, but there is little we can do," says an anguished senior official

from the Rifle Factory Ishapore which manufactures the SLRs and INSAS rifles. The most dubious brand ambassador for the indigenously designed 5.56 mm INSAS used by the army and paramilitary forces is West Bengal-based Maoist leader Koteswar Rao aka Kishen. TV grabs show him appearing, head covered, INSAS rifle slung across his back.

Today, the entire arsenal of the nearly 10,000-strong People's Liberation Guerrilla Army (PLGA), the military wing of the CPI (Maoist), comprises weapons looted from the security forces. These range from the .303 Enfield rifles to SLRs, INSAS and LMGs. The largest haul was the 2004 looting of district police armoury in Koraput, Orissa, which yielded over 500 rifles and several thousands rounds of am-

munition and the 2006 looting of 185 rifles and 25,000 rounds of ammunition from the home guards training centre in Giridih, Bihar.

Worse, vast quantities of OFB-produced ammunition too have been looted. This includes steel-core ammunition (where the bullet has steel inside instead of lead) made at OFB factories in Kirkee and Warangaon. The steel core gives the bullet a lethal velocity capable of shattering level-III bullet proof jackets. The Ministry of Home Affairs recently indented for 59,000 BP jackets which are useless against INSAS steel core ammunition. "Our steel core ammunition can penetrate even three mm mild steel sheets," OFB officials say.

What is also worrying, security experts say, is the theft of industrial explosives used in quarrying. OFB-manufactured Mine Protected Vehicles are designed to withstand a 14 kg explosive blast under their hull, mainly from the IEDs planted by militants in Jammu and Kashmir. But in the Red Corridor, where there is seemingly no shortage of explosives, there are no limits. Five years back, Naxals used nearly 80 kg in two IEDs which blasted an eight-ton MPV nearly 35 ft in the air, killing all the 24 police personnel from the sheer impact of the fall. "Such large quantities of explosives mean the Maoists can destroy even T-72 tanks," OFB officials say.

Maoists have triggered off 92 IED blasts in 2009 alone. According to security experts, the Maoists refuse external aid in the form of weapons evidently not to compromise on their 'revolutionary principles'. "The enemy must be finished, his weapons seized and he must be made powerless..." the Maoist manual exhorts.

The Stolen Arsenal

APRIL 6, 2010 75 CRPF men ambushed and killed. 82 weapons looted.

MARCH 15, 2007 55 policemen killed in Chhattisgarh. 48 rifles looted.

NOVEMBER 11, 2006 185 rifles looted from Home Guards Training Centre.

FEBRUARY 6, 2004 500 rifles looted from district police armoury in Koraput.

